

North America, coltsfoot is a common plant often found along roadsides and on verges and in open areas. The flowers are gathered in late winter, the leaves in summer.

Parts Used Leaves, flowers.

Constituents Coltsfoot contains flavonoids, about 8% mucilage (polysaccharides), 10% tannins, pyrrolizidine alkaloids, vitamin C, and zinc. The pyrrolizidine alkaloids may have a toxic effect on the liver, but are largely destroyed when the parts are boiled to make a decoction. The polysaccharides are anti-inflammatory and immunostimulant. The flavonoids are anti-inflammatory and antispasmodic.

History & Folklore For at least 2,500 years, coltsfoot has been taken as a cough remedy and smoked as a means to ease breathing. Dioscorides, a Greek physician of the 1st century CE, recommended it for dry coughs, and “for those who are unable to breathe except standing upright.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses An effective demulcent and expectorant herb, coltsfoot is one of the most popular European remedies for treating chest problems. In Europe, the leaves are preferred to the flowers (which contain higher amounts of pyrrolizidine alkaloids), but in China the flowers are preferred. Both parts of the plant are taken as a decoction for chest conditions. When used as a syrup or a medicinal cigarette, coltsfoot relieves asthma. This herb is used as a specific treatment for spasmodic coughs. It is particularly effective when used in combination with licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101), thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), and wild cherry (*Prunus serotina*, p. 257).

Research Extracts of the whole plant have been shown to increase immune resistance. In a Chinese trial involving 36 patients suffering from bronchial asthma, 75% showed some improvement after treatment, but the antiasthmatic effect was short-lived.

Cautions Do not use coltsfoot flowers. Do not take the leaves for more than 3–4 weeks at a time. Do not take coltsfoot during pregnancy or while breastfeeding. The herb is not suitable for children under 6. Coltsfoot is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.



Coltsfoot has long been used as a remedy for coughs.

Tylophora asmatika (Asclepidaceae) Asmatica, Indian Lobelia

Description Perennial twining climber with lance-shaped leaves and greenish flowers producing many flat seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Indian subcontinent, asmatica grows wild on the plains of India. The leaves are gathered when the plant is in flower.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Asmatica contains alkaloids (including tylophorine), flavonoids, sterols, and tannins. Tylophorine has anti-inflammatory and antitumor properties.

History & Folklore Asmatica has long been used in Ayurvedic medicine to induce vomiting and expectoration, and to treat dysentery and rheumatic conditions.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Considered a specific remedy for asthma, asmatica may relieve symptoms for up to 3 months. It is also beneficial in cases of hay fever, and is prescribed for acute allergic problems such as eczema and hives. It holds potential as a treatment for chronic fatigue syndrome and other immune system disorders. Asmatica may relieve rheumatoid arthritis, and may also be of value in the treatment of cancer.

Research Extensive laboratory and clinical research in India has established that asmatica is an effective remedy for asthma. In the 1970s, a number of clinical trials showed that a majority of asthmatic patients taking the herb for just 6 days gained relief from asthma for up to a further 12 weeks. However, subsequent studies have failed to reproduce these results. The leaves produce side-effects including nausea and vomiting.

⚠ **Caution** Take asmatica only under professional supervision.

Typha angustifolia (Typhaceae) Cattail, Pu Huang (Chinese)

Description Stout upright plant growing to a height of 6½ ft (2 m). Has long, flat, narrow leaves rising parallel to the stem, a distinctive brown cylindrical head of female flowers, and straw-colored male flowers immediately above.

Habitat & Cultivation Cattail flourishes in marshes, swamps, and other freshwater sites in both temperate and tropical zones, and is cultivated. The pollen is shaken off the plant while it is in bloom.

Part Used Pollen.

Constituents Cattail contains isorhamnetin, pentacosane, and sterols.

History & Folklore The pollen is highly inflammable and has been used in the manufacture of fireworks. The root is edible and has been eaten in times of famine. The young shoots can be eaten raw or cooked in spring, and are said to taste like asparagus (*Asparagus officinalis*, p. 174).



Cattail or pu huang is used to staunch wounds and stop internal bleeding.

Although “bulrushes” (the British and Irish name for cattails) are mentioned in the Bible, it is likely the plant being referred to is actually *Cyperus papyrus*.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Chinese herbal medicine, the astringent pollen has been employed chiefly to stop internal or external bleeding. The pollen may be mixed with honey and applied to wounds and sores, or taken orally to reduce internal bleeding of almost any kind—for example, nosebleeds, uterine bleeding, or blood in the urine. The pollen is now also used in the treatment of angina (pain in the chest or arm due to lack of oxygen to the heart muscle). In India, the dried pollen has been used for kidney stones, to treat nosebleeds and internal bleeding, as well as for painful menstruation. Cattail does not appear to have been used as a medicine in the European herbal tradition.

Research Chinese research suggests that cattail pollen protects blood vessels from inflammation and acts as an immunosuppressant.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.